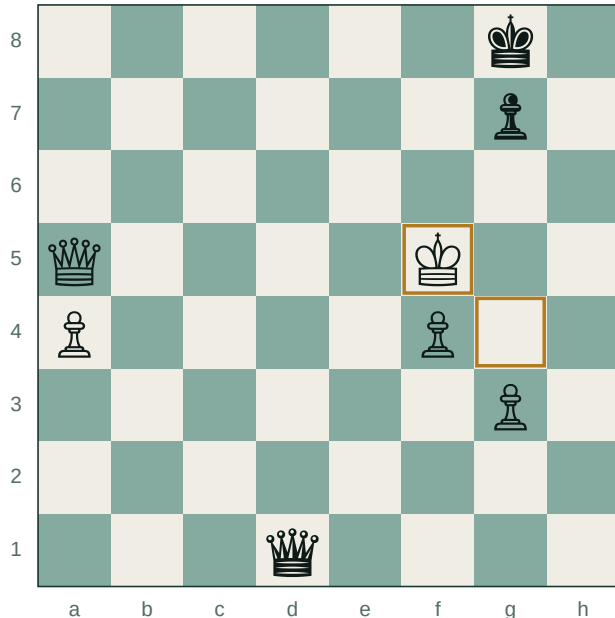


Queen-ending tactics: Black, move 44

Queen-ending tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 44.Kf5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

44...Qh5+ 45. Ke4 Qxa5

44...Qh5+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **45.Ke4**.

45...Qxa5 The queen captures the queen on a5.

At the end, nominal material is White 3 / Black 10 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +9:** the balance goes from -2 to +7. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A favorable-looking queen exchange can lead to a drawn pawn ending. Evaluate the new ending before simplifying.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Queens combine long-range checks with promotion support. King shelter and the order of checks often matter more than a small material lead.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect perpetual-check possibilities, queen trades, and checks that gain a tempo for a passed pawn.

The defending king is on f5. Geometrically undefended: queen on a5. Check for tactical protection.